pretence, no false answers to the interviewer's questions—just be Gunjan Saxena.'

'I'll remember, Papaji, and I'll also remember that I'm the daughter of Lieutenant Colonel Anup Kumar Saxena.'

Papaji was a commissioned officer in the Corps of EME in the Indian Army. I looked up at him and smiled as I playfully gestured a salute. Standing next to the bogie's door, my mother smiled. She was smartly dressed in a printed white suit with a plain white dupatta that day. As always, she wore a big, round, crimson bindi, placed perfectly between her pencil-thin, bristly brows. I could see a few wrinkles on the sides of her warm, expressive, beautiful eyes. Her coal-black, wavy hair, that had once cascaded down her back, was now tied in a bun at the nape of her neck. There was no outburst of emotions, no melodramatic moments, just her signature smile. And I knew how worried she was. I was travelling all by myself, and that too, for my first SSB. But she always chose to appear strong, rather than to exhibit her worries. When I had to leave home for the first time to join Hansraj College in Delhi, where I was supposed to pursue my BSc in anthropology, my brother was so worried that he argued with my parents to not let me go and my father lectured for hours before I left—but my mother, Mrs Kirti Saxena, didn't react. She just smiled and wished me strength and luck. She didn't cry that day; neither did she let me cry. No wonder she is the most composed in a family of short-tempered siblings and father . . . and a couple of crazy dogs.

They walked me to my seat. Lieutenant Colonel Anshuman Saxena, my year-and-four-month-older sibling whom I called Dada, had carefully tucked my suitcase underneath the seat and secured it to the frame with a steel chain. It was more of a ritual when travelling in Indian trains than a safety measure.

'You take care of yourself, Gunjan,' Dada said, looking at the two teenage boys sitting in front of my seat from the corner of his eye, and then continued loudly, 'even though my seat is in the adjacent bogie, I'll keep coming to check on you.' He punctuated every word with his index finger, ending with a wink. I nodded, even though I knew he was bluffing. It was